CERNO GLOBUS

FIELD INTELLIGENCE

Issue 006 Wednesday, October 28, 2026 · Biweekly, 4 pages

Home Services

Pest Control · Septic & Sewer · Landscape · Pool · Appliance Repair · Moving

Six trades, one publication. Every item is something that moves a number on your P&L, changes what you must do by law, or changes what parts and labor cost you.

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Water, sewer and trash collection prices rose 4.8% over the year to September, 1.1 points above the 3.7% all-items rate, with monthly gains of 0.4%, 0.5% and 0.2% from July through September.

LANDSCAPE
Aspire's survey of more than 1,000 commercial landscape owners and executives, reported October 13, found 79% saying growing revenue is a top goal for next year, with a majority planning crew pay raises this year as material and equipment costs rise.

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Pool Corporation's third-quarter net sales rose 4% to $1.50 billion but gross margin fell 60 basis points to 29.0%, which it tied to higher inbound freight costs and customer mix.

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Electronics and appliance store sales were $7.85 billion in September, up 0.6% from August and 9.4% from a year earlier, the Census Bureau reported October 15.

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BACKGROUND SIGNAL
The fraud that reads your invoices before it sends one

Read it online
This issue, and every one before it

MONEY

Rollins grew residential pest revenue only 2.3% organically in the third quarter, and operating margin fell 140 basis points to 20.5% as customer acquisition stayed under pressure.

Rollins reported third-quarter results on October 21: revenue of $1.09 billion, up 6.2%, but organic revenue up only 4.4%. Residential organic growth was 2.3%, commercial 6.6% and termite and ancillary 5.3%. Acquired businesses added $18.3 million of the quarter's revenue, which accounts for the gap between reported and organic growth.

Profit slipped while revenue grew. Operating income fell 1.0% to $222.9 million, operating margin fell 140 basis points to 20.5%, and adjusted EBITDA margin fell 170 basis points to 23.5%. Diluted earnings were $0.33 a share against $0.34. CEO Jerry Gahlhoff Jr. said: "We are disappointed with our third quarter performance and are acting with urgency."

Management pointed to customer acquisition. CFO Will Harkins said: "Residential customer acquisition remained under pressure in the third quarter." Rollins is moving marketing spend away from its traditional digital approach toward higher-return channels, including visibility in AI- and LLM-driven discovery.

Cash and buying continued. Free cash flow rose 28.8% to $235.5 million, helped by $63 million of tax-refund timing. Rollins spent $27.4 million on acquisitions in the quarter and $162.6 million in nine months, and repurchased $120.1 million of stock in the quarter. Nine-month revenue is up 8.0%, with organic growth of 5.5%.

What to do about it: Pull your last 12 months of booked residential jobs by source and divide marketing spend by new customers. Rollins is moving money out of traditional digital marketing, and your cost per lead may be moving too. This week, search your company name and your top three services in two AI assistants and a map search, screenshot what each says about you, and fix wrong hours, service areas or reviews. Shift some budget to channels you can count: referrals, neighbor mailers, repeat-service offers. Put cost per new customer in writing by November 15 so you can set the 2027 marketing budget against it, and ask any buyer who calls for retention and revenue per route before you discuss price.

Rollins Q3 2026 results release (Oct 21, 2026) · Rollins Form 10-Q, quarter ended Sept 30, 2026

PEST CONTROL

TWO ITEMS

DEMAND

Select Exterminating, a Franklin Square, N.Y., firm founded in 1959, bought Suburban Pest Control, Amherst Exterminators and On The Spot Pest Control, Pest Management Professional reported October 19.

Why it matters: The targets are Suburban in Hamburg, N.Y. (founded 1983), Amherst in Dunkirk, N.Y., and On The Spot in Metuchen, N.J. (established 2010, serving four New Jersey counties). The Aust Group advised on all three; terms were not disclosed. Regional operators are buying small firms in the quarter Rollins reported residential organic growth of 2.3%. If you may sell within two years, build a three-year file of customer retention, revenue per route and recurring-contract share, and ask an M&A adviser which of the three buyers weigh most.

PMP: Select Exterminating hat trick (Oct 19, 2026)

MONEY

Scorpion, a Salt Lake City marketing firm, acquired Coalmarch Marketing, a Raleigh, N.C., agency serving pest control and lawn care companies since 2004, Pest Management Professional reported October 20.

Why it matters: Coalmarch clients gain access to Scorpion's RevenueMAX platform, which the article describes as built to tie marketing to measurable revenue rather than just leads. Price and terms were not disclosed. Rollins said residential customer acquisition is under pressure,. If Coalmarch is your agency, ask in writing this week for your contract term, cancellation notice, any price change, who owns your ad accounts and call-tracking data, and booked jobs by source.

PMP: Scorpion acquires Coalmarch (Oct 20, 2026)

SEPTIC & SEWER

TWO ITEMS

MONEY

Water, sewer and trash collection prices rose 4.8% over the year to September, 1.1 points above the 3.7% all-items rate, with monthly gains of 0.4%, 0.5% and 0.2% from July through September.

Why it matters: BLS's CPI release of October 14 shows water and sewer and trash collection services up 4.8% from September 2025, with seasonally adjusted gains of 0.4% in July, 0.5% in August and 0.2% in September. Your customers' municipal sewer and trash bills are rising faster than prices in general. If your last price increase predates the spring, set the next one now: a dollar figure, an effective date, and written 30-day notice to contract customers.

BLS CPI release, September 2026 (Oct 14, 2026)

REGULATION

EPA's comment period on draft guidance for reducing PFOA and PFOS risk in biosolids closed October 5, and EPA's program page was updated October 6.

Why it matters: Bergeson & Campbell reported on July 14 that comments were due September 4 and that EPA says the guidance has no force of law and does not bind the public. It is aimed at treatment plant operators, landowners, farmers and state agencies. Haulers who deliver to plants or land-apply: ask each receiving plant and your state regulator in writing whether loads will be tested or restricted, and keep disposal receipts and site records. Docket: EPA-HQ-OW-2026-2509.

EPA: Draft PFOA/PFOS biosolids guidance page · Bergeson & Campbell: EPA seeks comment on biosolids draft

LANDSCAPE

TWO ITEMS

LABOR

Aspire's survey of more than 1,000 commercial landscape owners and executives, reported October 13, found 79% saying growing revenue is a top goal for next year, with a majority planning crew pay raises this year as material and equipment costs rise.

Why it matters: Landscape Management reported that operators are buying direct from suppliers to manage cost and price volatility, and that attracting and keeping skilled workers remains a priority. Toro announced OneFleet on October 21, offering fleet customers with an active Toro-brand fleet relationship up to 21% savings, depending on brand and category, across Exmark, Ventrac, mowing, compact equipment and irrigation. Ask your dealer in writing whether you qualify and for the term before ordering 2027 equipment, and price your 2027 renewals from your 2026 labor cost per hour.

Landscape Management: Aspire 2027 report (Oct 13, 2026) · Landscape Management: Toro OneFleet (Oct 21, 2026)

SUPPLY

CPSC warned on October 22 that PowRyte pressure washers sold on Amazon and eBay for $92 to $320 lack plug-top shock protection, and the seller has not answered recall requests.

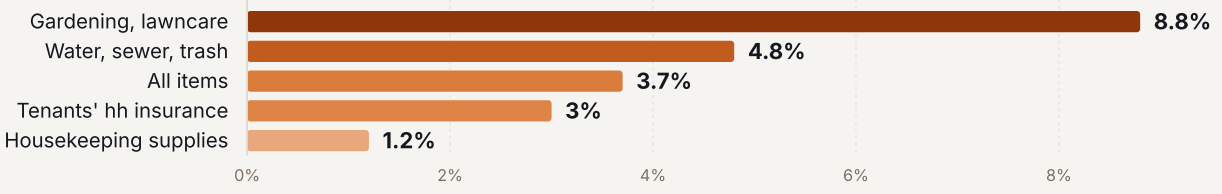
Why it matters: Product Safety Warning 27-036 says the washers lack an integrated immersion protection device on or near the power plug, with one incident reported on a unit without a GFCI. Owners are told to stop using them, cut the cord and not sell or give them away. Check every electric washer on your trucks for a plug-top GFCI, pull any PowRyte unit, and log brand and model on each equipment record.

CPSC warning: PowRyte pressure washers (Oct 22, 2026)

INFOGRAPHIC 1 / HOME SERVICE PRICES

Lawn care prices rose 8.8% in the year to September, more than twice the 3.7% all-items rate.

CPI-U, U.S. city average, 12-month unadjusted percent change to September 2026. BLS release of October 14, 2026.



Lawn care ran at 8.8%, water, sewer and trash at 4.8%, both above the 3.7% all-items rate. Not charted because they are below zero: appliances, down 1.0%, and moving, storage and freight, down 7.1%. BLS CPI release, September 2026 (Oct 14, 2026)

POOL

TWO ITEMS

MONEY

Pool Corporation's third-quarter net sales rose 4% to $1.50 billion but gross margin fell 60 basis points to 29.0%, which it tied to higher inbound freight costs and customer mix.

Why it matters: Pool Corp reported on October 22 that 3 points of the growth came from price, with maintenance and building materials also contributing; growth was 2% in the second quarter. Operating income fell 3% to $172.2 million as operating expenses rose 5% to $264.1 million, and nine-month gross margin was 29.3%, down 30 basis points. The company confirmed 2026 diluted EPS guidance of $10.66 to $10.96. Ask your supplier for its 2027 price list date in writing, and build a pass-through clause into service agreements.

Pool Corp Q3 2026 results release (Oct 22, 2026)

SUPPLY

Pool Corporation ended September with $1.2 billion of debt, up $104.9 million from a year earlier, 454 sales centers, and product inventories down 3% to $1.19 billion.

Why it matters: The October 22 release shows inventories of $1,185 million against $1,224 million a year earlier, and 454 sales centers against 456 at December 31, 2025, after two openings. Nine-month operating income fell 1% to $522.5 million and operating margin to 11.7% from 12.3%. A distributor carrying more debt and less stock into the off-season may favor early-order programs. Ask your branch what is on offer, confirm deposit and return terms in writing, and keep 30 days of your critical parts on your own shelf.

Pool Corp Q3 2026 results release (Oct 22, 2026)

APPLIANCE REPAIR

TWO ITEMS

DEMAND

Electronics and appliance store sales were $7.85 billion in September, up 0.6% from August and 9.4% from a year earlier, the Census Bureau reported October 15.

Why it matters: Census's advance estimate, seasonally adjusted and not adjusted for price, shows $7,853 million against $7,806 million in August and $7,179 million a year earlier; nine-month sales are up 7.0%. The category includes consumer electronics, so it is not an appliance-only count. Write your age-and-cost threshold for advising replacement into your quote sheet, and read Whirlpool's third-quarter release (October 26, 4:05 p.m. ET) and call (October 27, 8 a.m. ET) for parts and pricing remarks.

Census advance retail sales, Sept 2026 (Oct 15, 2026) · Whirlpool: Q3 results date notice (Oct 19, 2026)

REGULATION

CPSC warned on October 15 that Kalorik MAXX air fryer ovens with French doors can close on a user's arms, with dozens of burns reported, and the firm that sells them declined to recall.

Why it matters: The ovens were sold at Walmart, Home Depot and other retailers from April 2020 to January 8, 2024, and by The Legacy Companies after June 23, 2025. The original importers went out of business, and CPSC urges owners to dispose of the units. Do not accept these ovens for repair, parts or resale; hand customers the CPSC warning and note the refusal on the work order.

CPSC warning: Kalorik MAXX air fryer ovens (Oct 15) · CPSC recalls and warnings list, October 2026

MOVING

TWO ITEMS

MONEY

Consumer prices for moving, storage and freight fell 7.1% over the year to September, with seasonally adjusted drops of 1.2%, 1.9% and 2.3% in July, August and September.

Why it matters: BLS's October 14 CPI release shows the index falling while the all-items index rose 3.7%. If you are discounting to fill fall slots, set a floor at your fully loaded cost per crew hour and track bid win rate by quote size, so you can see whether a lower price is buying volume or only margin loss. Review every quote below the floor with the owner before it goes out.

BLS CPI release, September 2026 (Oct 14, 2026)

SUPPLY

Truck freight producer prices were up 19.3% over the 12 months to September and transportation and warehousing services prices rose 3.4% in September alone, BLS data show.

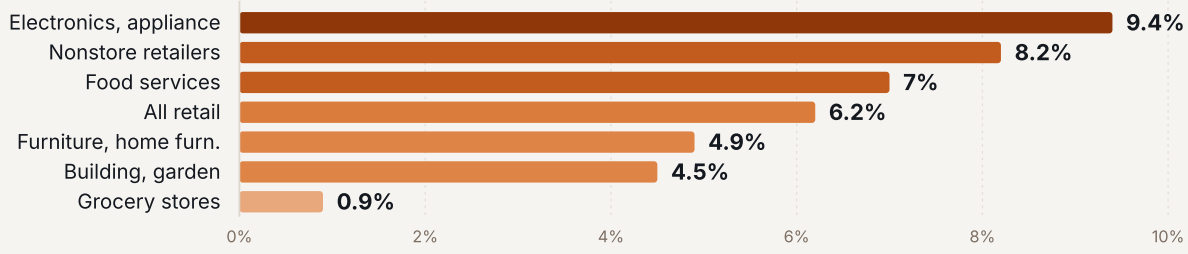
Why it matters: BLS puts transportation and warehousing services up 16.0% over twelve months, and final demand services rose 0.8% in September. A mover that subcontracts linehaul or buys freight capacity is paying those rates, while the consumer index for moving is falling 7.1%. Reprice long-distance and linehaul quotes from current carrier rates, shorten quote validity to 14 days, and write a carrier-cost adjustment line into estimates where your state tariff rules permit.

BLS: PPI up 6.3 percent in September (TED) · BLS PPI release, September 2026

INFOGRAPHIC 2 / STORE SALES GROWTH

Electronics and appliance store sales rose 9.4% in September from a year earlier, against 4.9% for furniture stores and 4.5% for building and garden dealers.

Census Bureau advance monthly retail sales, September 2026 release of October 15, 2026. Seasonally adjusted sales, percent change from September 2025, current dollars.

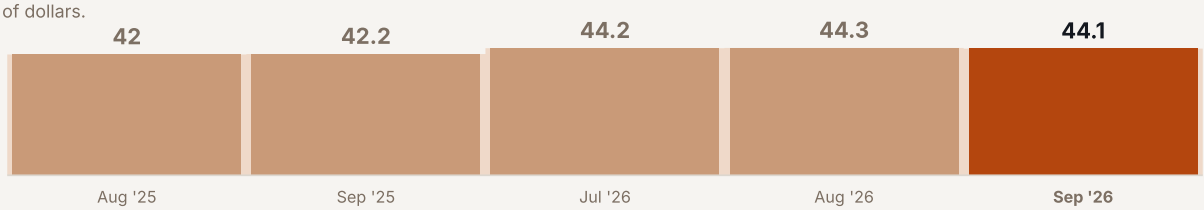


Electronics and appliance stores ran 9.4% above a year ago, furniture and home furnishings 4.9% and building and garden dealers 4.5%, against 6.2% for all retail. The figures are dollars, not units, and the electronics category includes consumer electronics. Census advance retail sales, Sept 2026 (Oct 15, 2026)

INFOGRAPHIC 3 / GARDEN AND BUILDING DEALERS

Building material and garden dealers sold $44.08 billion in September, 4.5% above a year ago but 0.6% below August.

Census Bureau advance monthly retail sales, September 2026 release of October 15, 2026. NAICS 444, seasonally adjusted, billions of dollars.



Sales were $42.18 billion in September 2025, $44.23 billion in July, $44.32 billion in August and $44.08 billion in September. The chart covers August and September 2025 and July through September 2026. Spending at building material and garden dealers is up 4.5% on the year but slipped in September. These are advance estimates and not adjusted for price. Census advance retail sales, Sept 2026 (Oct 15, 2026)

THE BACKGROUND SIGNAL

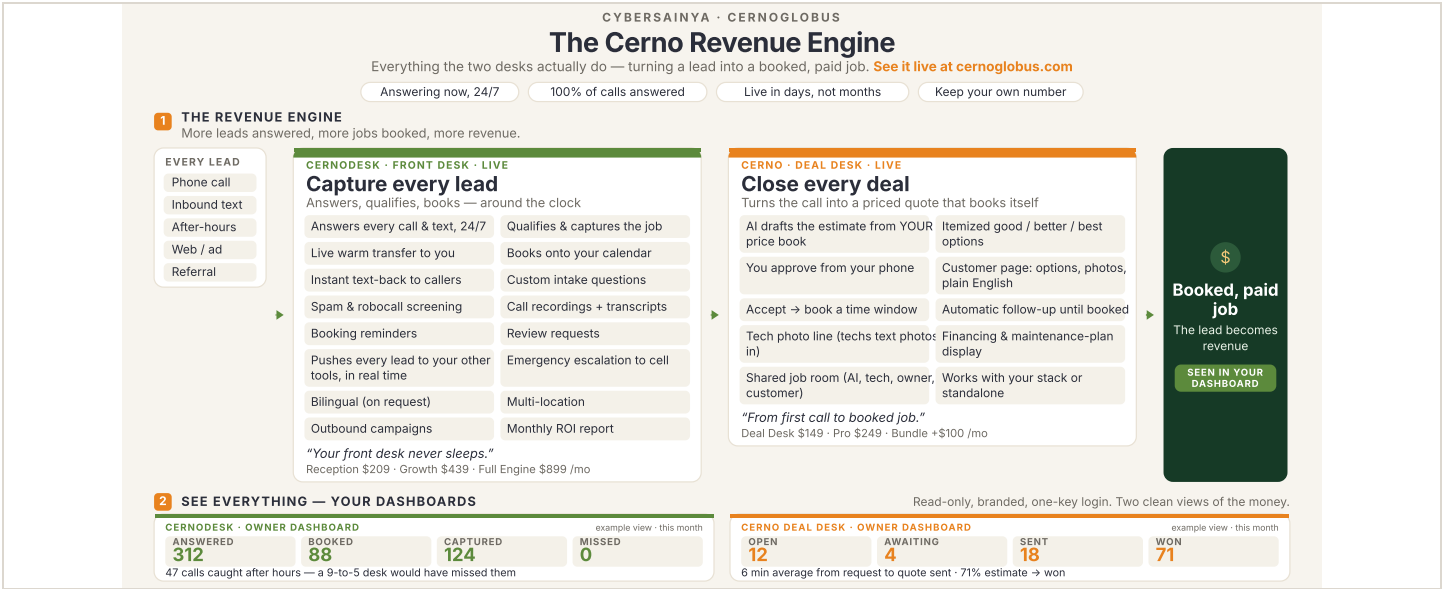
The fraud that reads your invoices before it sends one

The FBI's Internet Crime Complaint Center took 24,768 business email compromise reports in 2025, with losses of $3.05 billion — a record, after dipping to $2.77 billion in 2024 from $2.95 billion in 2023. Across all internet crime it logged 1,008,597 complaints and $20.88 billion in losses. Reported cases only, so read it as a floor.

Business email compromise, not ransomware, is the one that should concern a home services operator. Someone gets into a mailbox, reads until they understand how you invoice and who pays you, then sends a real-looking progress billing with different bank details. No malware, no warning — just a payment that never arrives and an argument about who eats it. A trade that emails estimates, service tickets and supplier invoices all day is the shape this is built for. The quieter number is adoption: under 20% of firms with fewer than 20 staff use AI at all.

What to do about it: You don't need a security program. You need multi-factor authentication on email and your accounting login, and one rule everybody follows: nobody changes bank details on the strength of an email or a call — you ring the number you already had on file and confirm. That covers most of it, and costs nothing. The part it doesn't — how the systems are set up — is the day job of our parent company, CyberSainya.

FBI Internet Crime Complaint Center, 2025 Internet Crime Report — reported cases only, rounded from $2,946,830,270, $2,770,151,146 and $3,046,598,558. U.S. Census Bureau, Business Trends and Outlook Survey, May 3, 2026.



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